

Legislative professionalism and perceptions of white-collar government

Journal of
Political
Institutions and
Political
Economy

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Received 22 October 2025
Revised 21 May 2026
Accepted 17 June 2026

Abstract

The professionalization of American state legislatures is among the most consequential modern institutional reforms in legislative politics. Yet a core tension persists: citizens disapprove of professionalized legislatures even though these chambers possess capacity-enhancing resources – such as staff support, higher salaries and longer sessions – that may improve representation and policymaking. We offer one explanation for this disapproval: citizens perceive professional legislatures as dominated by legislators from white-collar backgrounds. Consequently, the authors argue that opposition to professionalism stems, in part, from a belief that white-collar legislators may not represent society's interests broadly. Evidence from a preregistered conjoint experiment and observational analyses using the Cooperative Election Study supports this claim. Respondents associate professionalism with a legislature primarily composed of white-collar lawmakers, whom they do not believe govern to benefit the general public. These findings suggest that opposition to legislative professionalism likely reflects a rejection of white-collar government rather than repudiation of the institutional gains from professionalization.

Keywords Legislative professionalism, Social class, Descriptive representation, Conjoint experiment

Paper type Research paper

American state legislatures have evolved over their modern histories, with many moving from low-capacity “citizen” chambers to more professionalized institutions holding substantial policy agendas and political power (Malhotra, 2006; Squire and Hamm, 2005). Some existing research finds that professionalized legislatures are, in principle, better equipped to provide policy representation than citizen legislatures with comparably fewer resources (Maestas, 2000; Lax and Phillips, 2012). This theoretical advantage reflects



Funding: The Franco Family Institute for Liberal Arts and the Public Good at the University of Notre Dame provided funding support for this research.

Journal of Political Institutions and
Political Economy
© Emerald Publishing Limited
2689-4815
DOI 10.1108/JPIPE-10-2025-0027

capacity-enhancing resources – such as staff support, higher salaries and longer sessions – that facilitate policymaking and responsiveness (Maestas, 2003; Harden, 2016) [1]. But despite these benefits, citizens, on average, report negative attitudes toward professionalized legislatures and often favor less-resourced citizen legislatures instead (Squire, 1993; Kelleher and Wolak, 2007; Richardson *et al.*, 2012; Fortunato *et al.*, 2023).

Why some citizens hold negative attitudes about professional legislatures, despite their enhanced capacity, remains unclear. We argue that the disapproval stems, in part, from aversion to white-collar legislators – such as lawyers, doctors and educators – who are disproportionately represented in professionalized chambers (Carnes and Hansen, 2016). Specifically, we contend that citizens associate white-collar lawmakers with professionalized legislatures and expect them to prioritize policies that benefit the wealthy at the expense of American society more broadly. This expectation is consistent with existing evidence documenting public skepticism toward professionalized chambers (Squire, 1993; Kelleher and Wolak, 2007; Fortunato *et al.*, 2023; McCrain and O’Connell, 2023). However, our argument clarifies that such disapproval is due, in part, to citizens’ perceptions that white-collar legislators are overrepresented in professional legislatures.

To test this expectation, we pair experimental and observational evidence from a preregistered conjoint experiment ($n = 1,996$) and the Cooperative Election Study (CES). We find that, across both surveys, respondents associate professional legislatures with white-collar legislators, who they believe prioritize policies that do not benefit the respondents themselves or society in general. This pattern suggests that at least a portion of citizens’ disapproval of professional legislatures is rooted in opposition to their perceived class composition – not the institutional enhancements that come from greater legislative capacity.

Our findings offer important contributions at the intersection of political institutions and representation. First, they highlight a stark misalignment between citizens’ representational preferences and the social-class composition of American legislatures. Although our results indicate that Americans are skeptical about the over-representation of white-collar legislators, fewer than 2% of state legislators come from working-class backgrounds (Carnes and Hansen, 2024). Second, by linking attitudes toward legislative professionalism to perceptions of legislators’ class backgrounds, we show how institutional reforms can shape public evaluations of representation indirectly – through the class backgrounds citizens associate with professionalized chambers. Finally, our findings add to a growing literature documenting the political consequences of workers’ underrepresentation in American legislatures (Carnes, 2013; Carnes and Lupu, 2023; Lollis, 2024) by demonstrating how class-based descriptive representation also conditions public support for legislative institutions.

Consequences of legislative professionalism

Beginning in the 1960s, under-resourced state legislatures initiated reform efforts through a process of professionalization, aiming to equip their institutions with capacity more comparable to those available to members of the U.S. Congress. These reforms were primarily aimed at raising legislators’ salaries, expanding staff support, and lengthening time in session (Squire and Hamm, 2005). Today, state legislatures vary widely in their level of professionalization. States such as New Hampshire, Wyoming and Utah tend to pay legislators less, provide minimal staff support, and meet infrequently. In contrast, states such as California, New York and Massachusetts have highly professionalized legislatures that function similarly to Congress [2].

The resources that professionalism provides affect how legislators engage in policymaking (Jansa *et al.*, 2019; Kroeger, 2022; Makse, 2022), representation (Harden, 2016), communication (Payson *et al.*, 2022) and constituency service (Harden, 2016;

Landgrave and Weller, 2020; Garcia and Sadhwani, 2023). Professional legislatures, for example, are better equipped with tools to advance original legislation (Jansa *et al.*, 2019; Kroeger, 2022). Some scholars find correlational evidence that they are associated with improved policy representation, although other studies report low levels of congruence (cf. Maestas, 2000, 2003; Matsusaka, 2010; Lax and Phillips, 2012; Harden, 2016; Simonovits *et al.*, 2019; Caughey and Warshaw, 2022).

Professional legislatures also attract white-collar legislators (Carnes and Hansen, 2016). Existing work finds that the higher salaries in professional legislatures attract white-collar candidates, increase electoral competition and crowd out workers (Carnes and Hansen, 2016). Fewer than 2% of legislators in chambers that pay over \$75,000 are from working-class backgrounds, compared to over 7% in chambers where lawmakers receive only a nominal salary (Carnes and Hansen, 2016, 703). These findings indicate that although workers are numerically underrepresented in every state legislature (Lollis, 2024), their exclusion is most extreme in professionalized chambers [3].

Citizens' attitudes toward professional legislatures

On average, Americans hold clear preferences regarding the professionalization of the legislatures in their home states. When asked, respondents are less likely to approve of or have confidence in professional legislatures (Squire, 1993; Richardson *et al.*, 2012; Kelleher and Wolak, 2007). As Kelleher and Wolak (2007, 713) note, "people report greater confidence in [...] statehouses that resemble the ideal of citizen legislatures than those that resemble the U.S. Congress." However, while it is clear that citizens hold negative attitudes toward professional legislatures, the reasons *why* citizens may disapprove of institutions that are equipped with capacity-enhancing resources remain unclear.

One explanation is that citizens oppose the capacity-enhancing features of professionalized legislatures, such as higher salaries, expanded staff and longer sessions. Prior work finds that, particularly as legislatures began to professionalize, citizens opposed these reforms at the ballot box largely because they increased legislators' pay (Squire, 2012). More recent research, however, contradicts this perspective. Kirkland and Harden (2022) find that respondents in a survey experiment view legislatures with higher salaries or longer session lengths as better able to provide representation compared to low salary or short session chambers. Moreover, apparent opposition to professionalism could be partly informational; citizens are often poorly informed about state legislatures (Rogers, 2023a) and providing information about how capacity-enhancing institutions can facilitate policies that benefit constituents substantially increases support for professional legislatures (Fortunato *et al.*, 2023).

We offer an additional perspective to this multifaceted explanation of citizens' disapproval of professional legislatures. Citizens may object less to the particular capacity-enhancing institutional reforms associated with professional legislatures than to the *kinds of lawmakers* serving in these institutions. White-collar lawmakers are more prevalent in professional legislatures than in citizen legislatures (Carnes and Hansen, 2016), and, accordingly, we expect that citizens associate legislative professionalism with white-collar representation – an attribute they tend to evaluate negatively (Griffin *et al.*, 2020). There are several reasons to expect this association. First, professional legislatures more closely resemble the structure and function of Congress, where white-collar government – and its consequences – are most visible (Carnes, 2013). To the extent that citizens use Congress as a heuristic, they may infer that professionalized state legislatures are likewise dominated by white-collar lawmakers.

Second, citizens evaluate legislatures through the lens of perceived – rather than objective – descriptive representation (Stauffer, 2021; Clark and Rogers, 2025). Although state publics may be uncertain about the actual composition of their legislatures (Ahler and

Sood, 2018), they nonetheless form beliefs about who is included and excluded, and these perceptions shape their evaluations of both Congress and state legislatures (Stauffer, 2021). For example, when underrepresented groups perceive higher levels of their group's representation, their evaluations of a legislature improve – even when those perceptions are inaccurate (Stauffer, 2021; Clark and Rogers, 2025). If some citizens use professionalism as a cue for *who* serves in a legislature, then disapproval of professional legislatures may reflect perceptions that these chambers are dominated by white-collar lawmakers (which they are relative to citizen legislatures), rather than opposition to the capacity-enhancing resources that comprise the process of professionalization:

H1. Americans associate increased legislative professionalism with more white-collar representation.

Citizens' perceptions of which social groups are represented in legislatures shape their trust, perceived responsiveness and external efficacy toward those institutions (Tate, 2003; Stauffer, 2021). When women and Black individuals perceive greater representation of their group, they are more likely to view legislatures as responsive (Harden and Clark, 2016; Stauffer, 2021; Clark and Rogers, 2025). We argue that citizens apply this same heuristic to social class. If citizens perceive a legislature as disproportionately composed of white-collar lawmakers, they may expect it to be less responsive to the average American and more likely to produce policies that advantage affluent interests. As a result, some citizens may expect white-collar legislators to prioritize policies that are less likely to benefit people like them and the broader public:

H2. Americans believe that white-collar representatives are less likely to advance and pass policies that benefit people like them and society.

Taken together, we argue that some citizens' disapproval of professional legislatures is not driven by opposition to capacity-enhancing institutions. Instead, it stems, in part, from perceptions that white-collar legislators are overrepresented in professional chambers and from expectations about the kinds of policies these lawmakers prioritize in office.

Research design

To test these expectations, we combine experimental data from a preregistered conjoint survey experiment with observational data from a module on the 2016 CES. First, we fielded a preregistered, choice-based conjoint survey experiment through Prolific from March 28, 2024 through April 6, 2024 ($n = 1,996$) [4]. The sample was quota-matched to US adult population benchmarks on age, gender, and race; full sample demographics are reported in the Supplemental Appendix. Given that many survey respondents likely did not have a clear definition of legislative professionalism going into the study, we began by providing a definition. We avoid using the term “legislative professionalism” directly in the definition because it could prime respondents to over- or understate their evaluations of professional legislatures. Specifically, the definition we gave respondents was as follows: “Legislative capacity is the resources a legislature needs to function. Legislative capacity varies across legislatures, with some legislatures having many resources and other legislatures having few resources.”

Respondents then answered a standard set of demographic questions that asked information about their age, income, occupation, partisanship, state of residence and overall economic status. In the middle of the demographic question block, we included a pretreatment “manipulation check” to assess whether respondents internalized our definition of legislative capacity. We included this question prior to treatment to avoid biased estimates

that can result from dropping respondents based on post-treatment responses (Aronow *et al.*, 2019) [5].

Survey participants then completed five randomly assigned, pairwise comparisons between two profiles of hypothetical legislatures (Legislature A and Legislature B). Each profile randomly varied a set of attributes. The key attributes were the three components of legislative professionalism – session length, staff support and salary – and the legislature’s class composition (white-collar, working-class or mixed). In this research we define class using occupation, consistent with standard practice in political science (Carnes, 2013; Makse, 2019; Carnes and Lupu, 2023; Lollis, 2024). To ensure respondents interpreted “white-collar” and “working-class” consistently, we provided definitions directly in the profiles that respondents evaluated. We described white-collar legislators as those “who formerly worked as lawyers, doctors, and educators,” and working-class legislators as those “who formerly worked as farmers, factory workers, and in clerical occupations.” All attribute levels and their possible combinations are listed in Table 1.

After reading each profile, respondents were then asked to select the legislature that best aligns with the following three outcome questions:

- (1) Which legislature is best positioned to benefit society?
- (2) Which legislature is best positioned to benefit people like you?
- (3) Which legislature is most professional?

We estimate conditional marginal means – rather than average marginal component effects (AMCEs) – for each of our three outcome measures. Marginal means report the expected probability that a profile is chosen when a given attribute level is present, averaging over the distribution of the other attributes (Leeper *et al.*, 2020) [6]. We code respondents’ class backgrounds using the same occupation-based definition of class used in the conjoint profiles [7].

Conjoint experiment results

Figure 1 reports conditional marginal means for responses to the third outcome question – “Which legislature is most professional?” Regardless of their own class background,

Table 1. All potential attributes for choice-based conjoint random assignment

Feature	All possible options
Legislative session length	“1 month” or “3 months” OR “6 months” OR “Unlimited”
Total legislature staff	“50 legislature staff members” or “200 legislature staff members” OR “750 legislature staff members”
Legislator’s salary	“\$0” or “\$30k” OR “\$50k” OR “\$100k”
Class	“The newly elected legislature is made up primarily of white-collar legislators who formerly worked as lawyers, doctors, or educators.” or “The newly elected legislature is made up primarily of working-class legislators who formerly worked as farmers, factory workers, and in clerical occupations.” OR “The newly elected legislature includes legislators from a variety of occupation backgrounds”
Party in control	“Democrats” or “Republicans”
Bill introduction limits	“5 bill limit” or “Unlimited”
Session calendar posting requirements	“Session calendars must be posted 24 h before session convenes.” or “Session calendars are not required, permitting legislators to take up any desired issue”

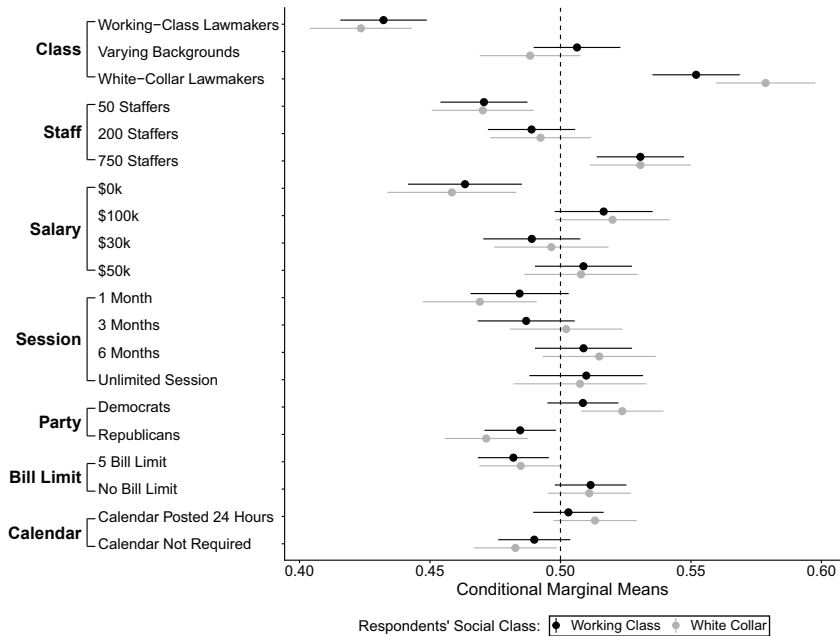


Figure 1. Respondents associated professional legislatures with white-collar lawmakers

Note(s): Points represent conditional marginal means estimating the probability that respondents associated a professional legislature with legislators’ class backgrounds, by institutional feature. Horizontal lines indicate 95% confidence intervals. Estimates are shown separately for working-class (black points) and white-collar (gray points) respondents. Marginal means report the expected probability that a profile was chosen when a given attribute level was present, averaging over the distribution of the other attributes

respondents rated legislatures composed mostly of working-class lawmakers as less professional, and rated legislatures composed mostly of white-collar lawmakers as more professional. This pattern reflects a substantively large effect: the gap in perceived professionalism between predominantly working-class and predominantly white-collar legislatures is nearly 10 percentage points in the marginal means. Legislatures with a mixed class composition fall between the two extremes. These findings support *H1*: respondents associate professional legislatures with white-collar lawmakers. Respondents also rated legislatures with lower staff levels and lower legislative salaries as less professional. Importantly, these effects are smaller than the influence of class composition on perceptions of professionalism, which is consistent with our argument. Overall, respondents primarily equate professional legislatures with white-collar legislators.

To test our second expectation, we asked respondents, “Which legislature is best positioned to benefit society?” [Figure 2](#) reports the conditional marginal means for this outcome. Respondents perceived legislatures composed largely of white-collar lawmakers – those they also rate as most professional – as least well-positioned to benefit society. Notably, this pattern holds among both working-class and white-collar respondents. In contrast, respondents rated legislatures with mixed class compositions and those composed primarily of working-class lawmakers as better positioned to benefit society. The magnitude of this

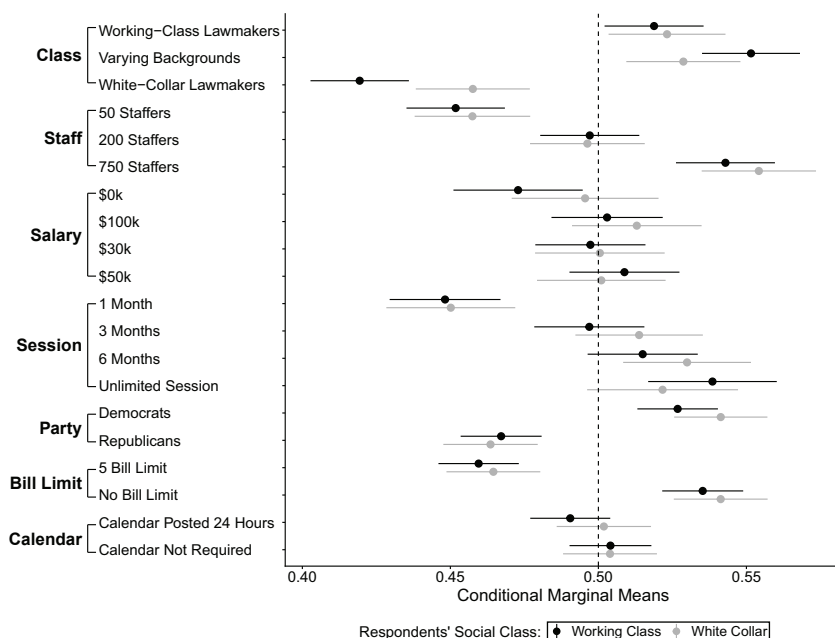


Figure 2. Respondents viewed white-collar legislatures as less well-positioned to benefit society

Note(s): Points represent conditional marginal means estimating the probability that respondents viewed a legislature as best positioned to benefit society, based on its class composition, by institutional feature. Horizontal lines indicate 95% confidence intervals. Estimates are shown separately for working-class (black points) and white-collar (gray points) respondents. Marginal means report the expected probability that a profile was chosen when a given attribute level was present, averaging over the distribution of the other attributes

effect is substantively large: the gap in perceived societal benefit between predominantly working-class and predominantly white-collar legislatures is nearly seven percentage points. This finding is consistent with *H2* [8].

Our results also indicate that respondents viewed unlimited bill introductions, larger staff sizes, longer session lengths and Democrat-controlled legislatures as more beneficial for society [9]. In contrast to prior work finding that some citizens hold negative attitudes about professional legislatures (Squire, 1993; Kelleher and Wolak, 2007; Richardson *et al.*, 2012), our findings suggest that state public view larger staffs and longer sessions – two hallmarks of professionalized legislatures – as beneficial for society (see also Kirkland and Harden, 2022). Consistent with our argument, however, respondents view white-collar representation in these chambers negatively. Together, these results indicate that aggregate disapproval of professional legislatures is not driven by opposition to capacity-enhancing institutions (which respondents evaluate positively), but instead reflects skepticism toward the white-collar representation that they associated with professionalized chambers.

To test our final expectation, we asked respondents “Which legislature is best positioned to benefit people like you?” Once again, results from Figure 3 indicate that both working-class and white-collar respondents rated legislatures composed primarily of working-class lawmakers as better positioned to benefit people like themselves, and rated predominantly white-collar

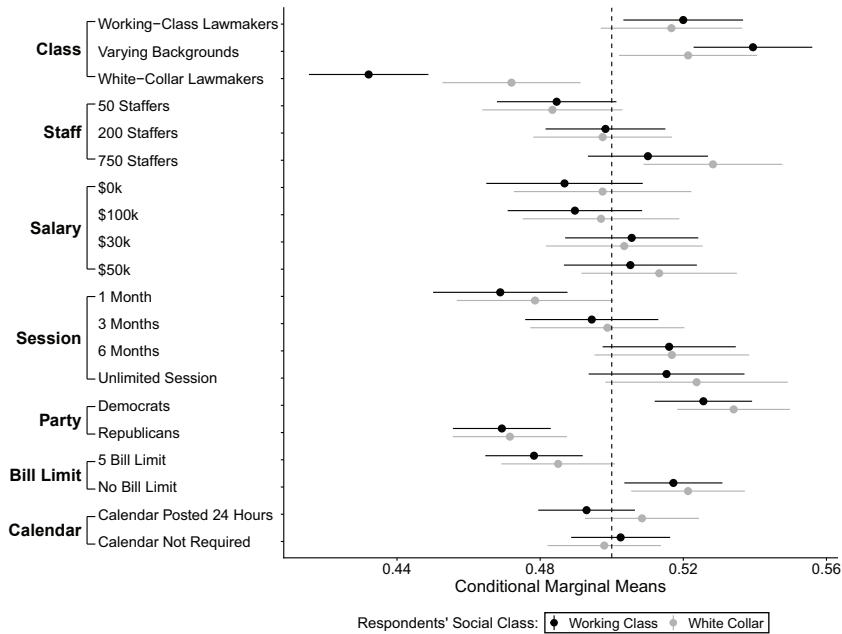


Figure 3. Respondents viewed white-collar legislatures as less well-positioned to benefit people like them

Note(s): Points represent conditional marginal means estimating the probability that respondents viewed a legislature as best positioned to benefit people like them based on its class composition, by institutional feature. Horizontal lines indicate 95% confidence intervals. Estimates are shown separately for working-class (black points) and white-collar (gray points) respondents. Marginal means report the expected probability that a profile was chosen when a given attribute level was present, averaging over the distribution of the other attributes

legislatures as least well-positioned. The substantive magnitude is similar to the previous outcome: the gap between perceptions of predominantly working-class versus predominantly white-collar legislatures is nearly six percentage points in the marginal means.

There is some heterogeneity by respondent class on this outcome: white-collar respondents viewed white-collar legislatures as less beneficial than working-class respondents reacted to them. Still, both groups rated white-collar legislatures as least well-positioned to benefit people like themselves. This pattern is also inconsistent with the idea that high occupational class respondents recognize personal gains from white-collar representation even if they perceive broader societal harms. Overall, the weight of these results indicates that the American public – regardless of class identity – tends to associate white-collar representation with professional legislatures and believe that those legislatures are suboptimal for benefitting members of the public themselves or society in general. These results suggest support for *H1* and *H2*.

Results by respondent party

One concern is that our results may be moderated by respondents’ partisanship. This possibility is plausible for two reasons. First, although our sample was quota-matched on

age, gender and race, it was not matched on party identification [10]. Based on self-reported partisanship, the sample includes 968 Democrats, 420 Republicans and 572 Independents. Given this imbalance, the pooled patterns we report may reflect the preferences of Democratic respondents more than those of Republicans or Independents. Second, the results reported above indicate that respondents rated Republican-controlled legislatures as less well-positioned to benefit themselves and society, suggesting that party control was a salient cue in their evaluations. If Democrats, Republicans and Independents differ in how they weight class composition and capacity attributes, pooled estimates may mask party-based heterogeneity in responses.

To test for this variation, we conducted the analyses reported in Figures 2 and 3 disaggregated by respondent partisan identification. We find that the results do *not* vary by party. Put differently, they are not driven by an overrepresentation of Democrats in the sample. Democrat, Republican and Independent respondents consistently viewed legislatures comprised of white-collar lawmakers as less beneficial, both to society (panel a) and themselves (panel b) [11].

Limitations of the conjoint experiment

Several limitations to our conjoint survey experiment are important to acknowledge. First, as with many conjoint designs, external validity is a concern. Although we find that respondents associate white-collar lawmakers with legislative professionalism – and, in turn, view white-collar legislatures as less responsive – these relationships may not translate directly to real-world settings. Conjoint experiments create an artificial decision environment in which respondents evaluate a fixed set of attributes, which could differ from how some citizens encounter and process information about legislatures outside of experimental conditions. Moreover, we provided respondents with a definition of legislative capacity at the start of the survey. We do not know whether these respondents would have responded similarly without this prompt. But lacking the prompt would have more closely resembled how citizens acquire information in the real world. To address these concerns, we complement the conjoint experiment with observational evidence from a CES module that measures respondents' perceptions of social class representation. The CES data mitigates two limitations of the conjoint design: (1) it was not explicitly designed to study, and does not define, legislative professionalism; and (2) it was not embedded in an experimental setting, reducing concerns about external validity.

CES observational survey

To address the inherent limitations of our conjoint survey experiment, we draw on data from a 2016 CES module designed by Carnes and Lupu (2022). In this survey – which was unrelated to the study of legislative professionalism – Carnes and Lupu (2022) measured class-related attitudes by asking respondents to (1) estimate the share of state legislators from working-class backgrounds in their states and (2) report the share they would prefer. We use these items to construct a variable, *Perceptions of Working-Class Underrepresentation*, which measures the difference between respondents' preferred and perceived levels of working-class representation. Higher values indicate a stronger desire for more working-class lawmakers than respondents believed existed at the time; lower values indicate a preference for fewer working-class lawmakers. This variable ranges from – 89 (perceiving far too many working-class lawmakers) to 100 (perceiving far too few), with a mean of 28.3. We also create a measure, *Legislative Approval*, which captures respondents' approval of their state legislatures. Responses are based on the question: “Do you approve of the way

each your state legislature is doing its job?” and range from 1 to 4, with higher values indicating stronger legislative approval.

Together, these measures allow us to assess two additional empirical relationships: (1) whether (objective) state legislative professionalism is associated with citizens’ perceptions of working-class underrepresentation, and (2) whether these perceptions are associated with lower legislative approval. The former allows us to assess whether our results hold in a nonexperimental environment that did not define capacity and where professionalism was measured using objective indicators (Bowen and Greene, 2014). The latter also enables us to test whether our main empirical findings hold in a nonexperimental context, but using a measure of legislative approval rather than external efficacy (i.e. whether legislatures are positioned to respond to citizens’ needs.) Importantly, the purpose of this CES analysis is to serve as a complement to the survey experiment – triangulating evidence and addressing limitations associated with the experimental design. It supports descriptive rather than causal inferences and should not be interpreted as testing a preregistered expectation.

To estimate the first relationship, we regress *Perception of Working-Class Underrepresentation* on each dimension of state legislative professionalism (Bowen and Greene, 2014) [12]. The first dimension is our independent variable of interest because it is represents the primary variation in professionalism, correlating highly with the Squire Index (Bowen and Greene, 2014, 288). We also control for a variety of relevant covariates measuring respondent characteristics and party control of respondents’ states at the time of the CES survey. Table 2 reports the results.

Consistent with our experimental findings, as the first dimension of professionalism increases, so too does the perceived gap between the proportion of working-class lawmakers that respondents want and those they believe exist, controlling for other confounders. In other words, those in more professionalized states hold stronger perceptions that white-collar

Table 2. Legislative professionalism, approval and perceptions of class representation

Independent variables	Perception of working-class underrepresentation	Legislative approval
<i>Professionalism (1d)</i>	0.967** (0.455)	–0.012 (0.015)
<i>Professionalism (2d)</i>	–0.522 (1.131)	0.169*** (0.037)
<i>Perception of Working-Class underrepresentation</i>	–	–0.005*** (0.001)
Respondent education	–2.683*** (0.687)	0.004 (0.023)
Respondent is female	–4.158** (2.099)	0.180* (0.070)
Respondent is nonwhite	–9.540*** (2.600)	0.136 (0.086)
Democrat control of state	–2.357 (3.776)	–0.354** (0.122)
Republican control of state	4.821 (3.071)	–0.308** (0.102)
Respondent birth year	–0.231*** (0.060)	0.007*** (0.002)
Respondent is democrat	2.022 (2.476)	0.007 (0.082)
Respondent is republican	–1.971 (2.706)	0.117 (0.089)
Family income	–0.034 (0.038)	–0.001 (0.001)
Intercept	494.187*** (119.033)	–10.815** (3.947)
Observations	886	688
Adjusted R ²	0.055	0.099

Note(s): Cell entries report regression coefficients with standard errors in parentheses. The dependent variable is the difference in respondents’ preferences for working-class representation and their perceptions of working-class representation in legislatures. The survey responses come from the 2016 Duke University Cooperative Election Study module. Team survey weights are included in the analysis. **p* < 0.05 (two-tailed)

lawmakers are overrepresented in their legislatures [13]. This estimate is statistically significant and substantively large. A one standard deviation increase in legislative professionalism corresponds with an increase in the dependent variable by more than 5 percentage points, or about 17% of a standard deviation in the gap of perceptions. Paired with our experimental evidence, this finding suggests that legislative professionalism is associated with perceptions of class representation (*H1*).

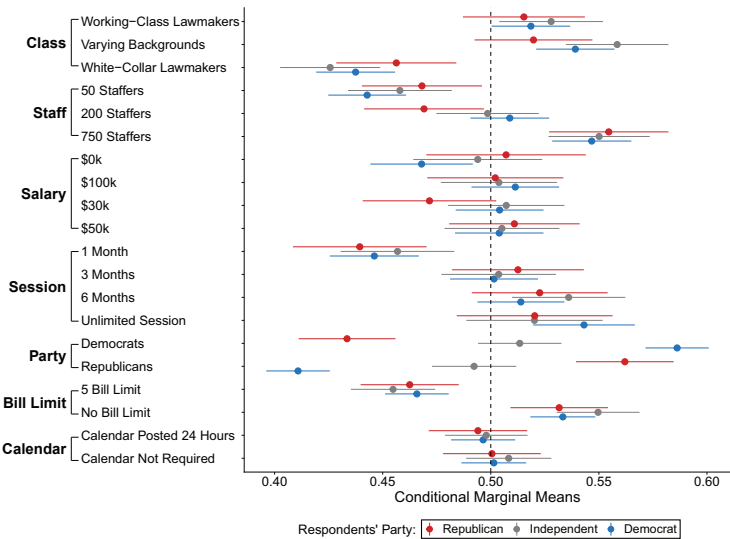
To assess whether the general pattern of our experimental results hold when using legislative approval as the outcome rather than measures of external efficacy, we regress *Legislative Approval on Perception of Working-Class Underrepresentation*, controlling for the professionalism of the legislatures in respondents' home states. As perceptions of working-class underrepresentation increase, approval of the state legislature decreases, controlling for the rest of the model. Put differently, respondents who believe there are too few working-class legislators report reduced approval of their legislatures, on average. This estimate is statistically significant and substantively meaningful: a two standard deviation increase in perceived underrepresentation is associated with a 34% standard deviation decrease in legislative approval. These findings are consistent with *H2*.

Overall, we find a general pattern of support for our expectations outside of the conjoint experiment. Observed legislative professionalism is positively associated with the perception that working-class citizens are underrepresented in state legislatures and that perception predicts a drop in state legislative approval. While this secondary observational analysis falls short of causal identification, we view it as useful descriptive context that bolsters the results of the experiment. The weight of our evidence suggests support for the conclusion that the occupational class composition of state legislatures is one plausible explanation for state publics' aversion to the professionalization of their legislatures.

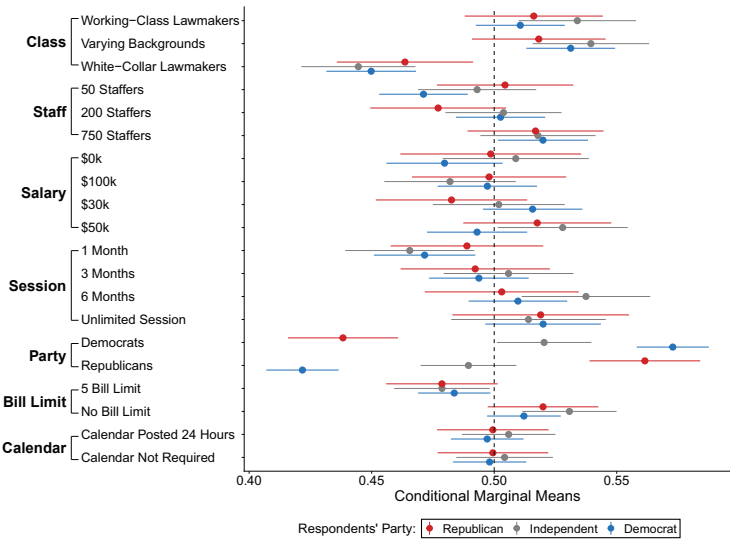
Conclusion

American state legislatures have professionalized over their modern histories, which scholars contend has largely expanded their policymaking power (Squire and Hamm, 2005; Kousser, 2005) and influence relative to other actors such as interest groups (Garlick *et al.*, 2025) and the governor (Kousser and Phillips, 2012; Birkhead, Harden and Windett, 2026). Yet despite the capacity-enhancing resources associated with professionalized legislatures, Americans hold negative attitudes toward them (Squire, 1993; Kelleher and Wolak, 2007; Richardson *et al.*, 2012; Fortunato *et al.*, 2023). In this paper, we offer one explanation for this reaction: citizens may disapprove of professional legislatures because they expect them to be dominated by white-collar lawmakers – a group many citizens view negatively. We combine evidence from a conjoint survey experiment with observational data from the CES and show that, across both analyses, some citizens associate legislative professionalism with white-collar representation and, in turn, perceive white-collar legislatures as less well-positioned to benefit themselves or society.

This research builds on existing work by showing that citizens' perceptions of descriptive representation – rather than objective group representation – shape legislative approval and efficacy (Stauffer, 2021; Clark and Rogers, 2025). Our findings suggest that, like gender and race, perceived social class composition also conditions how citizens evaluate legislatures. When legislatures are composed primarily of white-collar lawmakers – a pattern most common in professional legislatures – citizens infer that these institutions are less well-positioned to benefit them or society broadly. Thus, state publics' negative attitudes toward professionalization are less about their capacity to create policy and more about who citizens believe is actually carrying out that function.



(a) Which legislature is best positioned to benefit society?



(b) Which legislature is best positioned to benefit people like you?

Figure 4. Respondents viewed working-class and mixed-class legislatures as best-positioned to benefit society and respondents personally, regardless of partisanship

Note(s): Points represent conditional marginal means estimating the probability that respondents viewed a legislature as best positioned to benefit society (top panel) or people like themselves (bottom panel), based on its class composition and institutional features. Horizontal lines indicate 95% confidence intervals. Estimates are shown separately by respondents' party identification (Democrat, Independent, Republican). Marginal means report the expected probability that a profile was chosen when a given attribute level was present, averaging over the distribution of the other attributes

Normatively, our findings identify a representational dilemma related to the capacity and composition of political institutions. Reforms designed to enhance legislative capacity may unintentionally deepen public skepticism if they also crowd out working-class legislators. Thus, even if professionalization improves lawmakers' ability to produce policy and represent constituents, these resources may not translate into greater public efficacy or approval. Efforts to reform political institutions therefore cannot be evaluated solely in terms of capacity-enhancing resources. Instead, our findings suggest that support for legislatures depends critically on who citizens believe holds power within them. Reforms that increase institutional resources without addressing representational disparities may ultimately exacerbate the problems they are intended to solve.

Although our results indicate that some citizens view white-collar legislatures as poorly positioned to benefit themselves or society, it remains unclear whether these perceptions align with actual representation and policy outcomes. Existing work has been limited in assessing legislative responsiveness, in part because of identification challenges (Achen, 1978; Matsusaka, 2010). Future research may therefore examine whether citizens' perceptions of unresponsive, white-collar government are empirically warranted using research designs that yield stronger causal leverage (e.g. Matsusaka, 2026). It may be that professional legislatures – often dominated by white-collar lawmakers – are less likely to enact policies that advantage working-class Americans, and more likely to produce outcomes that disproportionately benefit the affluent. Evaluating these claims, however, requires credible causal identification. Future work should assess whether the public's perceptions of white-collar government are reflected in observable policy outputs and distributional outcomes.

Acknowledgements

The authors thank Dan Bowen, Connor Huff, Craig Volden, David Fortunato, and Josh McCrain for their helpful comments on the manuscript.

Notes

- [1.] Although this existing evidence suggests that professional legislatures provide better representation broadly, the findings are not causally identified (see Achen 1978; Matsusaka 2010). Moreover, legislators' preferences remain a dominant predictor of their behavior compared to those of constituents, whose central role is the selection of like-minded representatives (e.g. Matsusaka 2026).
- [2.] Legislative professionalism in the American states is both theoretically and empirically defined relative to Congress, and varies continuously rather than discretely. The three traditional components of professionalism – session length, legislator salary and staff support – are strongly correlated in Bowen and Greene's (2014) data spanning 1974–2019. Session length and salary correlate at +0.60; session length and non-salary legislative expenditures per legislator correlate at +0.41; and salary and expenditures per legislator correlate at +0.64, indicating that a legislature that is professional is less resource-constrained compared to part-time, citizen legislatures.
- [3.] Table 5 in the supplementary material reports estimates of the association between legislative professionalism, legislators' salary, and the share of working-class legislators. These results show that workers are less likely to be represented in professional legislatures and legislatures with higher salaries.
- [4.] The preregistration plan can be found in Appendix Section 1 (supplementary material). We specified subgroup-specific hypotheses (i.e. how white-collar and working-class respondents' attitudes differ toward professional legislatures). In this paper, we argue that all respondents associate legislative professionalism with the class composition of a legislature and the policies

it produces, irrespective of their class identity. Although the specific hypotheses in our preregistration differ slightly from those presented here, we include the preregistration to demonstrate that our expectations before conducting the conjoint experiment are consistent with the results and argument presented in this paper.

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- [5.] We note that the pretreatment questions and definitions in our study reflected the language of legislative capacity, rather than legislative professionalism, which was the concept we ultimately asked respondents to evaluate. Prior research demonstrates that most citizens have limited knowledge of state legislative institutions – especially when described using researchers’ terminology (Rogers, 2023a, 2023b). For this reason, we provided respondents with a brief, accessible definition of the core concept they were being asked to assess. While we believe it was necessary to offer a working definition to aid comprehension, we deliberately avoided a direct definition of professionalism to minimize priming effects. Moreover, the definition we provided was neutral: it framed legislative capacity as the basic resources a legislature needs to function. It was not a normatively positive portrayal of capacity, but rather a fact-based one. Finally, we do not maintain that citizens’ limited knowledge of state legislatures renders their attitudes nonexistent or unmeasurable. Indeed, existing research demonstrates that some citizens do have attitudes about legislative professionalism (Squire, 1993; Fortunato *et al.*, 2023). Instead, we argue that scholars can – and should – offer contextual information when asking about topics that may be difficult for respondents to conceptualize. In our view, supplying a definition of legislative capacity was both justified and necessary for this case.
 - [6.] Unlike AMCEs, marginal means do not require a reference category because they do not summarize effects relative to an omitted baseline, making them especially straightforward to interpret in subgroup comparisons (Leeper and Tilley, 2020).
 - [7.] Respondents are coded as working class if they report currently or previously working as a contractor, construction worker, office or clerical worker, public safety worker, retail or service worker, or in a trade job (Lollis, 2024). All other respondents are coded as white-collar.
 - [8.] This effect should be interpreted as respondents’ expectations about which legislature is better to generate societal benefits, rather than as a direct measure of actual policy outputs, given that the question asked which legislature was “best positioned,” not “most likely,” to benefit people like them (or society).
 - [9.] This result likely reflects the fact that our sample was primarily made up of Democrats. We examine treatment heterogeneity by party in the next subsection.
 - [10.] This option was not available from Prolific at the time the experiment was fielded.
 - [11.] Disaggregating by respondents’ partisan identification reveals modest heterogeneity in responses to non-class at tributes. Figure 4 shows that Democrats and Independents reacted to legislatures with working- or mixed-class lawmakers as better positioned to benefit society, whereas Republican respondents’ evaluations are not statistically significant. A similar pattern appears for the “benefit people like you” outcome: Republicans did not favor working- or mixed-class legislatures, while Independents did. Democrats viewed mixed-class legislatures as positioned to be beneficial for themselves, but did not similarly favor exclusively working-class legislatures. Despite these differences, the subgroup results consistently indicate that respondents perceived predominantly white-collar legislatures as producing worse outcomes for both themselves and society, supporting H2.
 - [12.] Building on the Squire Index (Squire, 2017), Bowen and Greene (2014) leverage multidimensional scaling to uncover the underlying dimensions of commonly used professionalism indicators. The components of the Squire Index, of which Bowen and Greene use slight variants, are (1) the number of days a legislature is in session, (2) the size and/or investment in legislative staff, and (3) legislators’ salaries. Their approach yields a two-dimensional structure that varies considerably across states and over time (in contrast to the unidimensional Squire Index).

- [13.] Respondents were randomly assigned to state their class representational preferences for state legislators, members of Congress, and city council representatives. The results presented here do not disaggregate based on whether the respondent was randomly selected into either of these groups. In Section 4 of the Appendix (Supplementary material), we subset the dependent variable based on whether the respondent was asked about a state legislature, Congress or city council. Consistent with our expectations and findings here, the coefficient is positive and statistically significant for state legislatures, and not statistically significant for Congress or city council.

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Further reading

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Supplementary material

The supplementary material for this article can be found online.

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